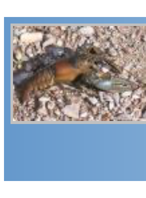


Faxonius virilis
(Virile Crayfish)
Crustaceans-Crayfish
Native Transplant

Collection Info
Point Map
Species Profile
Animated Map
Impacts

Alan Schmierer, Public Domain

Faxonius virilis (Hagen, 1870)

Common name: Virile Crayfish

Synonyms and Other Names: *Orconectes virilis* (Hagen, 1870). *Faxonius virilis* underwent a reclassification in August 2017, changing the genus of non-cave dwelling *Orconectes* to *Faxonius* (Crandall and De Grave 2017).

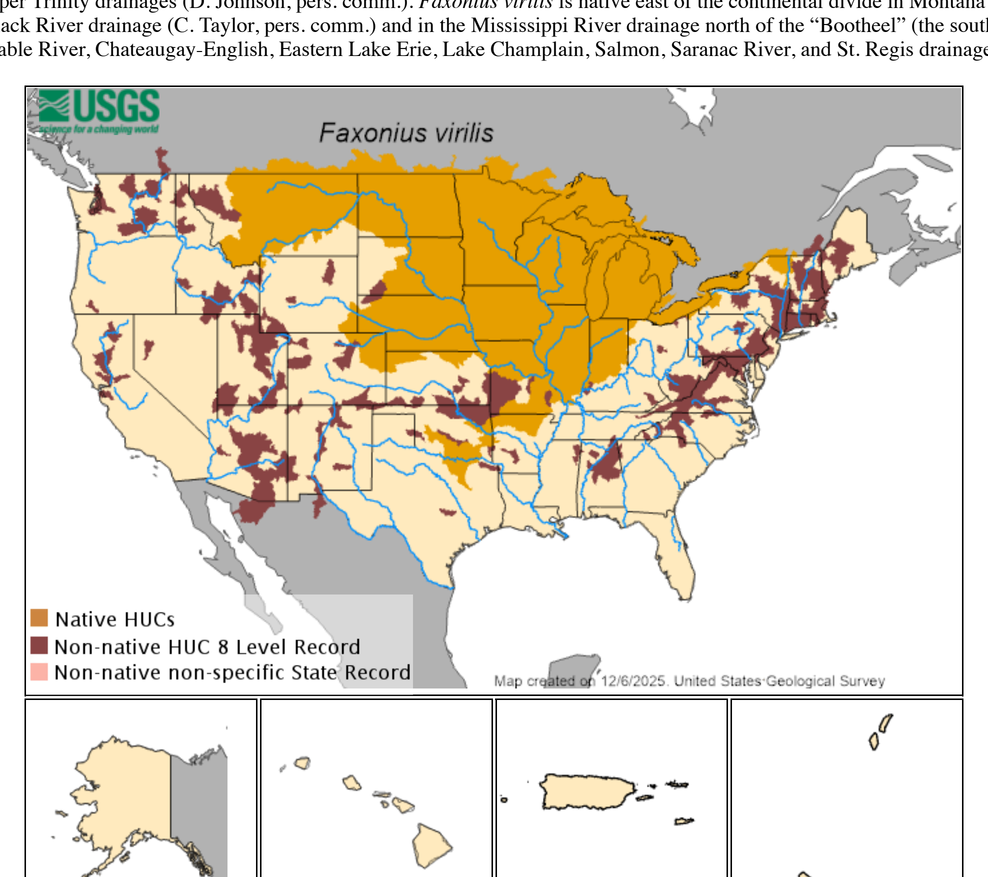
Taxonomy: available through ITIS

Identification: Individuals of this species can vary in color, ranging from a light- to olive-brown body with dark brown markings on each abdominal segment. Upper walking legs and chelae can be bluish. Tips of chelae are orange. Individuals have a long, broad rostrum and broad, flattened chelae with long fingers (Crocker and Barr 1968; Taylor et al. 2015). There is taxonomic confusion surrounding *F. virilis* and *F. causeyi* (Hobbs 1989). *Faxonius nais* is also often confused with *F. virilis*. They differ anatomically in gonopod structure; the lengthier gonopod element is more curved in *F. nais* (Johnson and Johnson 2008).

Size: Individuals up to 13.1 cm carapace length have been collected (Z. Barnett, unpublished data).

Native Range: Broadly, *F. virilis* is native to the Great Lakes, Missouri River, upper Mississippi River, and lower Ohio River and up to east of the continental divide in Montana (Taylor et al. 2015), with disjunct populations in the Black River in Missouri and Arkansas, the upper White River in Oklahoma and Arkansas, the Red River in Texas and Oklahoma, and Lake Champlain in New York (C. Taylor, pers. comm.).

Its native range in Arkansas and Oklahoma is uncertain, but it is known to be native in the Upper Black River, Upper Illinois River, and Upper White River drainages in northern Arkansas and eastern Oklahoma (C. Taylor, pers. comm.) and possibly drainages along the Texas-Oklahoma border (D. Johnson, pers. comm.). Its native range in Texas is uncertain; probably includes northeastern Texas in Bois D'arc-Island, Denton, East Fork Trinity, Elm Fork Trinity, Farmers-Mud, Lake Texoma, and Upper Trinity drainages (D. Johnson, pers. comm.). *Faxonius virilis* is native east of the continental divide in Montana (Crocker and Barr 1968). Its native range in southern Missouri is uncertain, but it is probably in the Upper Black River drainage (C. Taylor, pers. comm.) and in the Mississippi River drainage north of the "Bootheel" (the southeastern corner of Missouri; B. Williams, pers. comm.). Its native range in New York includes the Ausable River, Chateaugay-English, Eastern Lake Erie, Lake Champlain, Salmon, Saranac River, and St. Regis drainages (Crocker 1957; C. Taylor, pers. comm.).



Hydrologic Unit Codes (HUCs) Explained
Interactive maps: Point Distribution Maps

Nonindigenous Occurrences:

Table 1. States with nonindigenous occurrences, the earliest and latest observations in each state, and the tally and names of HUCs with observations†. Names and dates are hyperlinked to their relevant specimen records. The list of references for all nonindigenous occurrences of *Faxonius virilis* are found here.

State	First Observed	Last Observed	Total HUCs with observations†	HUCs with observations†
AL	1989	2017	10	Cahaba; Guntersville Lake; Locust; Lower Coosa; Middle Coosa; Middle Tallapoosa; Sipsey Fork; South Atlantic-Gulf Region; Upper Black Warrior; Upper Coosa
AZ	1976	2023	25	Agua Fria; Big Chino-Williamson Valley; Bill Williams; Black; Brawley Wash; Canyon Diablo; Chevelon Canyon; Fort Pearce Wash; Little Colorado Headwaters; Lower Colorado Region; Lower Lake Powell; Lower Salt; Lower San Pedro; Lower Verde; Middle Gila; Middle Little Colorado; Rillito; Rio De La Concepcion; San Francisco; Silver; Tonto; Upper Gila-San Carlos Reservoir; Upper San Pedro; Upper Santa Cruz; Upper Verde
AR	2019	2019	1	Upper Ouachita
CA	1939	2005	13	Big Chico Creek-Sacramento River; Butte Creek; California Region; Lower Pit; Lower Sacramento; Lower Sacramento; Sacramento-Stone Corral; San Francisco Bay; San Joaquin; Upper Cosumnes; Upper Putah; Upper Sacramento; Upper Stony
CO	1993	2022	6	Big Thompson; Colorado Headwaters-Plateau; Lower Yampa; Middle South Platte-Cherry Creek; Purgatoire; Upper South Platte
CT	1979	2011	9	Farmington River; Housatonic; New England Region; Outlet Connecticut River; Quinebaug River; Quinnipiac; Saugatuck; Shetucket River; Thames
DC	1989	1989	1	Middle Potomac-Anacostia-Occoquan
ID	1999	2025	16	Bear Lake; Clearwater; Coeur d'Alene Lake; Goose; Idaho Falls; Lake Walcott; Little Wood; Lower Boise; Lower Henrys; Middle Bear; Pend Oreille Lake; Portneuf; Salmon Falls; Teton; Upper Snake-Rock; Upper Spokane
IL	1987	1987	1	Highland-Pigeon
KS	2002	2019	4	Kaw Lake; Lower Cottonwood; Middle Arkansas-Slate; Upper Walnut River
KY	1995	1995	1	North Fork Kentucky
ME	1979	2024	7	Lower Kennebec River; New England Region; Piscataqua-Salmon Falls; Piscataquis River; Saco River; Upper Androscoggin River; Upper Kennebec River
MD	1960	2012	12	Cacapon-Town; Conococheague-Opequon; Gunpowder-Patapsco; Lower Susquehanna; Mid Atlantic Region; Middle Potomac-Anacostia-Occoquan; Middle Potomac-Catoctin; Monocacy; North Branch Potomac; Patuxent; Upper Chesapeake; Youghiogheny
MA	1979	1992	9	Blackstone River; Charles; Chicopee River; Concord River; Housatonic; Merrimack River; Narragansett; New England Region; Quinebaug River
MS	1989	2014	1	Upper Tombigbee
MO	1974	2021	14	Elk; Harry S. Truman Reservoir; Lake O' The Cherokees; Lake of the Ozarks; Little Osage; Lower Gasconade; Lower Marais Des Cygnes; Marmaton; Niangua; Pomme De Terre; Sac; South Grand; Spring; Upper St. Francis
MT	1988	2022	6	Blackfoot; Fisher; Flathead Lake; Lower Clark Fork; Lower Flathead; Swan
NE	2005	2005	1	Upper White
NV	1986	2017	2	Granite Springs Valley; Lower Virgin
NH	1979	2025	6	Black River-Connecticut River; Merrimack River; New England; Pemigewasset River; Saco River; Winnipesaukee River
NJ	1989	2023	3	Hackensack-Passaic; Mid-Atlantic Region; Middle Delaware-Musconetcong
NM	1983	2013	7	Jemez; Middle San Juan; Mora; Rio Grande-Albuquerque; Rio Hondo; Upper Gila-Mangas; Upper Rio Grande
NY	1936	2009	13	Black; Hackensack-Passaic; Housatonic; Hudson-Hoosic; Hudson-Wappinger; Lower Hudson; Middle Hudson; Mohawk; Rondout; Sacandaga; Saugatuck; Schoharie; Seneca
NC	1980	2020	9	Lower Dan; Middle Roanoke; Roanoke Rapids; Santee; South Fork Catawba; Upper Catawba; Upper Little Tennessee; Upper New; Upper Yadkin
OH	2000	2000	2	Ashtabula-Chagrin; Licking
OK	1969	1998	18	Bird; Black Bear-Red Rock; Caney; Chikaskia; Cimarron Headwaters; Kaw Lake; Lake O' The Cherokees; Lower Canadian-Walnut; Lower Neosho; Lower Salt Fork Arkansas; Lower Verdigris; Middle North Fork Red; Middle Verdigris; Mountain Fork; Spring; Upper Cimarron; Upper Cimarron-Bluff; Upper Cimarron-Liberal
OR	2022	2022	1	Middle Rogue
PA	1986	2024	11	Brandywine-Christina; Conococheague-Opequon; Crosswicks-Neshaminy; Gunpowder-Patapsco; Lehigh; Lower Delaware; Lower Susquehanna; Lower West Branch Susquehanna; Middle Delaware-Musconetcong; Monocacy; Schuylkill
RI	1979	2009	3	Blackstone River; Narragansett; New England Region
SC	2018	2024	1	Lower Catawba
TN	1989	1993	1	Upper French Broad
TX	1978	2019	3	El Paso-Las Cruces; Lower Sulpher; San Gabriel
UT	1965	2021	19	Bear Lake; Duchesne; Escalante Desert; Great Salt Lake; Lower Green-Diamond; Lower Lake Powell; Lower San Juan; Lower Virgin; Lower Weber; Price; Provo; Rush-Tooele Valleys; San Rafael; Spanish Fork; Strawberry; Upper Colorado-Kane Springs; Upper Lake Powell; Upper Virgin; Upper Weber
VT	1979	1989	8	Ammonoosuc River-Connecticut River; Black River-Connecticut River; Deerfield River; Lamoille River; St. Francois River; Waits River-Connecticut River; White River; Winooski River
VA	1928	2020	12	Appomattox; Maury; Middle Potomac-Anacostia-Occoquan; Middle Potomac-Catoctin; North Fork Holston; North Fork Shenandoah; Shenandoah; South Fork Shenandoah; Upper Clinch, Tennessee, Virginia; Upper James; Upper New; Upper Roanoke
WA	2006	2024	11	Chief Joseph; Duwamish; Franklin D. Roosevelt Lake; Lake Chelan; Lake Washington; Lower Crab; Lower Yakima; Methow; Puget Sound; Sanpoil; Upper Columbia-Priest Rapids
WV	1970	2017	12	Coal; Conococheague-Opequon; Elk; Gauley; Greenbrier; Lower Kanawha; Lower New; Middle New; North Branch Potomac; Potomac; Shenandoah; Upper Kanawha
WY	1986	2016	5	Blacks Fork; Popo Agie; Upper Bear; Upper Green-Flaming Gorge Reservoir; Upper Powder

Table last updated 12/8/2025

† Populations may not be currently present.

Ecology: *Faxonius virilis* is found in streams with moderate flow and turbidity, abundant cover, muddy, sandy, or rocky substrate and stable water levels (Crocker and Barr 1968; Maude and Williams 1983; Z. Barnett, pers. comm.). This species is inhibited by high velocity flow (Maude and Williams 1983). *Faxonius virilis* does not burrow, but may tunnel (Pflieger 1996). Mating occurs during two periods: August to October and April to May, and eggs are laid in spring (Crocker and Barr 1968). Pflieger (1996) observed larger males than females in Missouri, while Z. Barnett (pers. comm.) reported no size difference in Alabama.

Means of Introduction: Probable introduction methods include bait bucket introduction (Larson and Olden 2011; Kilian et al. 2012) and intentional stocking for forage (Larson and Olden 2011). It has been stocked as forage in **Montana** by Montana Fish, Wildlife and Parks (Sheldon 1989) and in **Utah** (Johnson 1986) in several locations. Welsh and Loughman (2015) have shown that the *Faxonius virilis* is capable of using fish-specific dam passages to move upstream in areas in which they are introduced.

Status: *Faxonius virilis* is established in 24 states: **Alabama** (Taylor et al. 2007), **Arizona** (Davidson et al. 2010), **California** (Ruiz et al. 2000), **Colorado** (Clark and Lester 2005; Hobbs 1989; Martinez 2012), **Connecticut** (Beauchene 2011), **Idaho** (Lester and Clark 2005; Idaho Species Catalog 2016), **Maine** (Crocker 1979), **Maryland** (Schwartz et al. 1963), **Massachusetts** (Crocker 1979; Taylor et al. 2007), west of the continental divide in **Montana** (Sheldon 1989), **Nevada** (Johnson 1986), **New Hampshire** (Crocker 1979; Taylor et al. 2007), **New Mexico** (Taylor et al. 2007), **North Carolina** (Cooper and Armstrong 2007; Simmons and Fraley 2010), **Ohio** (Thoma and Jezerinac 2000; Taylor et al. 2015), **Pennsylvania** (GBIF 2016; Smithsonian Institution 2014), **Rhode Island** (Crocker 1979; Taylor et al. 2007), **Tennessee** (Hobbs 1989; Illinois Natural History Survey 2017; Taylor et al. 2007), **Utah** (Taba et al. 1965; Johnson 1986; Clark and Lester 2005; Larson and Olden 2011), **Vermont** (Guarino et al. 2012; Taylor et al. 2007; Crocker 1979), **Virginia** (Virginia Fish and Wildlife Information Service 2016), **Washington** (Larson et al. 2010), **West Virginia** (Loughman and Welsh 2010), and **Wyoming** (Johnson 1986; Hubert 1988; Larson and Olden 2011). It is likely a failed introduction (no longer present) in **Mississippi** due to no recent collections (S. Adams, pers. comm.). Its status is unknown in **New Jersey** (Hobbs 1989; Taylor et al. 2007), as the only reported introduction was from Hobbs (1989).

Impact of Introduction:

Summary of species impacts derived from literature review. Click on an icon to find out more...

Ecological | Economic

Introduction of *F. virilis* can potentially cause decline or local extirpation of native crayfish (Loughman and Welsh 2010) and threaten freshwater biodiversity and macroinvertebrate community abundance and structure (Hanson et al. 1990; Clark and Lester 2005; MDNR 2016). This species is known to eat juvenile reptiles and amphibians, fish eggs, and macroinvertebrates (Recsetar and Bonar 2015). In the Netherlands, water bodies that have been invaded by *F. virilis* have shown decreases in water quality and macrophyte (plant) biomass (Roessink et al. 2017).

Faxonius virilis is the most abundant and widespread non-native crayfish in Maryland, and is associated with the decline of native spinycheek crayfish (*F. limosus*) and Allegheny crayfish (*F. obscurus*). Both native species are now extirpated from many watersheds where *F. virilis* is currently abundant (MDNR 2016).

Remarks: *Faxonius virilis* abundance decreased with stream restoration, including substrate modification by travertine and exotic fish predation (Adams and Marks 2016). Using this species as a human food resource can also potentially decrease the abundance of introduced populations (Crocker 1957; Pflieger 1996).

The native range of *F. virilis* in Arkansas, Missouri, Oklahoma, and Texas is uncertain. Additional native drainages are likely in Oklahoma and southern Missouri (C. Taylor, pers. comm.; D. Johnson, pers. comm.). The connectivity of native range drainages in Texas and Arkansas to adjacent drainages in Oklahoma and southern Missouri imply that these drainages in Oklahoma and southern Missouri might be native (C. Taylor, pers. comm.; D. Johnson, pers. comm.).

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Other Resources:
Orconectes virilis (Global Invasive Species Database)

Brief Guide to Crayfish Identification in the Pacific Northwest

US Fish and Wildlife Service fact sheet

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